

Where to put only

Teaching guide

Make clear what you are limiting.

Understand the distinction

Only limits a person, thing, action, amount, or time. Put it close to the element you want to limit when clarity matters: Only Jo called means nobody else called; Jo called only Sam means Sam was the only recipient.

In speech, stress and context also shape the meaning. I only bought two can be understood naturally even if only is not immediately before two. Do not assume every everyday placement is wrong; revise when a reader could misunderstand.

Compare the patterns

PERSON

Only Jo called Sam.

Nobody other than Jo called Sam.

RECIPIENT

Jo called only Sam.

Jo called no one except Sam.

ACTION

Jo only called; she did not visit.

The action was limited to a call.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Which says Sam was the sole recipient: Only Jo called Sam / Jo called only Sam?

- A. Only Jo called Sam.
- B. Both sentences make Sam the only recipient.
- C. Jo called only Sam.

2. Choose the sentence with the same meaning: No one except Leo replied.

- A. Leo only replied to Ana.
- B. Only Leo replied.
- C. Leo replied only.

3. Can spoken stress help clarify only?

- A. Yes. Stress makes written word order irrelevant.
- B. No. Spoken stress never affects meaning.
- C. Yes. Stress and context can identify the focus.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Which pair moves only so the first sentence limits the person and the second limits the drink?

A. Ana ordered only tea. Only Ana ordered tea.

B. Only Ana ordered tea. Only Ana ordered coffee.

C. Only Ana ordered tea. Ana ordered only tea.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. C. Jo called only Sam.

Only limits Sam.

A: This makes Jo the only caller, not Sam the only recipient.

B: The position of only changes which person is singled out.

2. B. Only Leo replied.

Only is next to the person being limited.

A: This introduces Ana and does not say that no one else replied.

C: This can restrict what Leo did, not identify Leo as the sole person replying.

3. C. Yes. Stress and context can identify the focus.

In writing, a clearer position may help.

A: Speech can clarify focus, but careful word order still helps written readers.

B: Stress can show which part of the sentence only limits.

4. C. Only Ana ordered tea. Ana ordered only tea.

The first singles out Ana; the second singles out tea.

A: These meanings occur in the opposite order.

B: Only limits Ana in both sentences; it does not switch to limiting the drink.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-18.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Which pair moves only so the first sentence limits the person and the second limits the drink?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.